democratic leaders might suppress information that reflects poorly on their policies or governance (Kono 2006; Schuessler 2010).

While these dynamics apply broadly, an important and underexplored source of variation in information-sharing behavior is whether a state is led by a populist leader. As argued throughout this book, populist leaders have distinct incentives to withhold or distort information. Their skepticism of elites, aversion to technocratic expertise, and emphasis on state sovereignty all contribute to a general hostility toward IOs. Populists often view IOs as "elitist" entities that impose constraints on state behavior and sovereignty. This makes information withholding a particularly appealing tactic for them, as suppressing critical data can obstruct IOs' ability to justify interventions or enforce rules. The prior chapter offered evidence in this vein.

Populists are especially likely to withhold data that are costly or difficult to collect independently. For example, producing accurate economic or environmental data requires specialized expertise, significant funding, and time-consuming analysis (McGarity and Wagner 2010). By cutting funding to domestic expert bureaucracies or politicizing their operations, populist leaders can weaken the capacity for data generation. Examples abound: Populist leaders have suppressed data on pesticide use, pollutant levels, and greenhouse gas emissions to limit IOs' ability to monitor or critique their policies.[4]

In contrast, data that are more accessible to IOs through independent means—such as satellite imagery or other publicly available sources—is harder for populists to manipulate. For instance, GDP data can be approximated using satellite-based measures of nighttime light density (Chan et al. 2019), and large-scale manipulation of metrics like unemployment rates would require coordinated efforts across multiple bureaucracies (Li 2017).

4.2.1 Strategies of Information Withholding

Populist leaders, with their hallmark skepticism of elites and technocrats, often undermine IOs by obstructing their ability to gather information. This obstruction can take several forms, both direct and indirect, and reflects populists' broader disdain for the authority and oversight IOs represent.